That Sarabhai wasn't too happy with the result became clearer to me a month before his death in December 1971, when he spoke to me before sending me off to a Rolls Royce facility in Scotland. That November he told me things weren't going the way he wanted and that he was planning to revamp the organisations. When I was abroad, Sarabhai was found dead in Halcyon Castle, a seaside resort in Kovalam, Trivandrum on 30 December.

But now, in 1967, Sarabhai was still experimenting. To accommodate the PhD group, Sarabhai founded the Space Science & Technology Centre (SSTC) with himself as the director and Murthy as the associate director. The PhD group would not cooperate with Murthy. On this side, I found it difficult to work with Kalam who was vigorous in developing solid boosters as much as dismissing liquid propulsion. One day, with SSTC in mind, I told him I want to leave. Kalam was upset. Kalam had immersed himself in developing what would later be known as the series of Rohini sounding rockets. Kalam was developing D-75 ('D' stood for Dreamer, according to Kalam, and 75, in mm, was the diameter of the rocket). There I learned from Kalam how sometimes making a small rocket is tougher than making a big one. Around the same time, SSTC also started developing a 75 mm diameter rocket. Ground tests were done in Veli, a sleepy fishing village near Thumba; and often the head or tail part of the rocket would burst in the trial and error run.

I kept insisting that I have to leave Kalam's team. Finally he allowed me to apply to SSTC, which readily took me in. Ironically, at SSTC, I was again assigned work on solid propulsion. As I nursed the liquid dream, Kalam went on to develop larger versions of Rohini, RH300, RH560 and RH1000, which went on to become the booster for the SLV-3 rocket.

In 1969, virtually intimidated by the abundance of scientist scholars around me, I decided to study, lest I might end up an also-ran. A natural choice was a post-graduate course in Trivandrum Engineering College. This was one time I came near regretting my decision not to pursue courses in Caltech University and Princeton University in the US because I had to be near my ailing mother. I got admission for MTech in heat power at the Trivandrum Engineering College. SSTC—and TERLS—then did not have a